

NINE GOLD MEDALS

Class 9 English – Kaveri | Poem 5 | David Roth

Detailed Poetry Solutions + Appreciation + Exam Practice

The poem narrates a Special Olympics hundred-yard race in which one athlete falls, the other runners stop, help him up and finish the race together. Current Kaveri references identify it as the companion poem to Chapter 5. ■cite■turn0search1■turn0search6■

1. POEM INFORMATION

Item	Details
Title	Nine Gold Medals
Poet	David Roth
Genre	Narrative / inspirational poem
Setting	A Special Olympics race
Main event	Nine athletes participate in a hundred-yard dash; one falls and the others help him
Central values	Empathy, compassion, sportsmanship, cooperation, dignity and humanity
Main contrast	Winning individually vs. supporting another person

2. STANZA-WISE EXPLANATION

Stanzas 1–2: Preparation and excitement

The athletes have trained for months and arrive at the starting line. The atmosphere is energetic and expectant. The competitors are ready to give their best in the hundred-yard race.

Stanzas 3–4: The race begins

The starting signal sends the athletes forward. They run with determination, while the crowd watches. At this stage the event looks like an ordinary competitive race focused on reaching the finish line first.

Stanzas 5–6: The turning point

The youngest athlete stumbles and falls on the asphalt. His fall changes the meaning of the race. Instead of continuing towards individual victory, the other athletes stop and return to him.

Stanzas 7–8: Nine gold medals

The athletes help the fallen runner up and then move together towards the finish line, holding hands. The crowd gives a standing ovation. The nine smiling faces and nine gold medals represent a different kind of victory—one based on compassion and collective achievement.

3. IMPORTANT WORDS & MEANINGS

Word/Phrase	Meaning
dashed	ran very quickly
stumbled	lost balance / almost fell
staggered	walked or moved unsteadily
anguish	extreme mental or physical pain
asphalt	hard road surface
finish line	line marking the end of a race
standing ovation	prolonged applause while the audience stands
beaming	smiling brightly with happiness
contestants	people taking part in a competition
pistol	starting gun used to signal the race

4. POETIC DEVICES & APPRECIATION

Feature	Explanation
Alliteration	Repeated initial sounds create musical emphasis; e.g. sound patterns around phrases such as "standing still".
Visual imagery	The runners, the fall on the asphalt, the athletes holding hands and the beaming faces create clear pictures.
Auditory imagery	The pistol/start signal and the crowd's response help the reader hear the event.
Contrast	The poem moves from competition and speed to cooperation and walking together.
Symbolism	The nine gold medals symbolize moral victory and sportsmanship, not merely speed.
Tone shift	The tone moves from excitement to concern, compassion and inspiration.
Repetition / emphasis	Repeated references to the athletes and the finish line strengthen the narrative focus.

5. REFLECT AND RESPOND

Q1. Distinguish Olympics, Special Olympics and Paralympics.

The Olympics are the major international multi-sport games for elite athletes under the Olympic movement. The Special Olympics movement provides sports opportunities and competition for people with intellectual disabilities. The Paralympics are major international competitions for eligible athletes with disabilities, with sport-specific classification systems.

Q2. Empathy, sympathy and compassion

Term	Meaning
Empathy	understanding or sharing another person's feelings from their perspective
Sympathy	feeling concern or sorrow for someone's difficulty
Compassion	concern for suffering combined with a desire to help

Q3. Words associated with empathy

Understanding, listening, kindness, respect, patience, sensitivity, support, care, cooperation, inclusion and perspective-taking.

6. CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

I. Match the contextual meanings

Word/Phrase	Answer
dashed in the dirt	fell/was thrown down onto the ground in the race context
stumbled	almost fell / lost balance
staggered	moved with difficulty or unsteadily
anguish	extreme pain or distress
asphalt	road material / hard road surface

II. Gist of the stanzas

The exercise asks students to connect each gist statement with the appropriate stanza. The narrative progression is: **preparation** → **race begins** → **athlete falls** → **runners stop** → **help is given** → **athletes finish together** → **crowd responds** → **nine medals**.

III. Appreciation

The poem is effective because it tells a simple story but changes the reader's idea of what winning means. The strongest emotional moment is not the start of the race but the decision of the other athletes to return to the fallen runner.

7. CRITICAL REFLECTION – EXTRACTS

Extract 1 – model answers

- **What happens to the race?** The runners stop rather than continuing towards the finish line.
- **What quality is highlighted?** Kindness and empathy.
- **How is the tone affected?** It becomes sympathetic, emotional and inspiring.
- **How might the fallen athlete feel?** He may feel hurt and disappointed initially, followed by gratitude and encouragement when the others return.
- **Does this change the meaning of the race?** Yes. The race becomes a demonstration of cooperation and humanity rather than a contest based only on speed.

Extract 2 – model answers

- **How do the contestants feel at the end?** They are happy and proud because they have completed the race together.
- **Why are nine gold medals significant?** They symbolize that all nine athletes shared the achievement through sportsmanship and collective support.
- **What values are represented?** Unity, teamwork, compassion and dignity.
- **How might the audience react?** With amazement, admiration and a standing ovation.
- **Meaning of the final idea:** Their smiling faces and action communicate more powerfully than any verbal explanation.

8. CRITICAL REFLECTION – LONG ANSWERS

Q1. How do the first two stanzas create the atmosphere?

They establish anticipation, excitement and competitive energy. The athletes have trained for months, the race is about to begin and the crowd is ready to watch. This energetic atmosphere makes the later decision to stop and help the fallen athlete even more meaningful.

Q2. How might the youngest athlete have felt when he fell?

He may have felt physical pain, embarrassment, disappointment and fear that the race was lost. His vulnerability becomes the turning point that allows the other athletes to demonstrate empathy and sportsmanship.

Q3. Why were the athletes eager to begin the race?

They had trained for the event and wanted to test themselves in competition. They were eager to perform their best and reach the finish line.

Q4. What does the transformation of the hundred-yard dash into a walk symbolize?

It symbolizes the transformation from individual competition to collective support. Speed stops being the most important goal; helping another person becomes the meaningful achievement.

Q5. How would the poem change if it focused only on individual achievement?

The poem would become an ordinary story of competition and winning. It would lose the emotional turning point and its message that compassion and sportsmanship can redefine success.

Q6. How do language and tone engage the reader?

The simple narrative language makes the events easy to visualize. Short, active descriptions create movement, while the emotional turn after the fall creates suspense. The final image of nine athletes holding hands leaves a memorable emotional impression.

Q7. What is the poet's purpose?

The poem encourages readers to value empathy, cooperation and human dignity. It suggests that helping another person can be a more meaningful form of victory than defeating competitors.

9. VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

Adjective–noun collocations

Examples from or closely connected to the poem include **standing ovation**, **young boy**, **gold medals**, **final line**, **loud applause**.

Adjective	Possible collocating nouns
gold	medal, trophy, standard, opportunity
standing	ovation, position, water
young	boy, athlete, runner, child
loud	applause, cheer, noise
final	line, round, event, result

10. LISTEN AND RESPOND – PATRICK GOMES

The listening task is a radio talk about Patrick Gomes, described as a special athlete and coach. The transcript states that his track-event journey began in 1991 in Chennai and that he was selected in football for the Special Olympics World Summer Games in 1995 while at the Okhla Centre of Learning and Development. ■cite■turn0search22■

For the True/False and MCQ listening items, students should listen for exact details such as years, places, sport, selection and achievements. The exercise is intentionally listening-based; the transcript should be used to verify each response rather than guessing from the poem.

11. WRITING TASK – THREE SLOGANS

1. Different Abilities, Same Dreams
2. Together We Win
3. Courage Beyond Limits

12. SPEAKING – MODEL RESPONSE

"I believe the Special Olympics promote equality, confidence and meaningful participation. They give athletes an opportunity to demonstrate their abilities and encourage society to look beyond stereotypes. The most important lesson is that competition does not have to remove compassion. A sporting event can celebrate both achievement and humanity."

13. ADDITIONAL EXAM QUESTIONS

Q1. Why is the title 'Nine Gold Medals' significant?

The title initially suggests a conventional competition in which one winner receives gold. But the poem reverses that expectation: all nine athletes receive gold because they finish together after helping one another. The title therefore becomes a symbol of shared moral victory.

Q2. Explain the contrast between running and walking.

Running represents speed, competition and individual achievement. Walking together represents cooperation, patience and equality. The change from running to walking marks the poem's central transformation.

Q3. What does the standing ovation signify?

It shows that the audience recognizes the athletes' act of compassion as worthy of exceptional admiration. The applause celebrates sportsmanship rather than simply the fastest performance.

Q4. What is the central message of the poem?

True success is not measured only by being first. Empathy, cooperation and the willingness to help another person can represent a deeper and more meaningful victory.

14. MCQs

The poem is written by

- A. David Roth
- B. Rabindranath Tagore
- C. William Blake
- D. R. K. Narayan

Answer: A

The athletes participate in a

- A. swimming race
- B. hundred-yard dash
- C. marathon
- D. relay

Answer: B

The race is associated with the

- A. Special Olympics
- B. World Cup
- C. Commonwealth Games
- D. Asian Games

Answer: A

What happens to the youngest athlete?

- A. He wins immediately
- B. He falls
- C. He leaves the stadium
- D. He refuses to run

Answer: B

The other athletes

- A. continue without him
- B. return to help him
- C. call officials only
- D. stop permanently

Answer: B

The race changes from a dash to a

- A. jump
- B. walk
- C. swim
- D. march alone

Answer: B

The athletes finish

- A. separately
- B. holding hands
- C. in silence at different times
- D. after leaving the track

Answer: B

The audience gives a

- A. warning
- B. standing ovation
- C. penalty
- D. lecture

Answer: B

There are

- A. eight gold medals
- B. nine gold medals
- C. ten gold medals
- D. one gold medal

Answer: B

The poem's tone changes from excitement to

- A. anger
- B. compassion and inspiration
- C. comedy
- D. fear

Answer: B

'Anguish' means

- A. extreme distress
- B. celebration
- C. speed
- D. pride

Answer: A

'Staggered' means

- A. moved unsteadily
- B. ran fastest
- C. shouted loudly
- D. slept

Answer: A

The central value highlighted is

- A. selfishness
- B. empathy
- C. wealth
- D. fame

Answer: B

The gold medals symbolize

- A. only physical speed
- B. shared sportsmanship and humanity
- C. financial success
- D. school rank

Answer: B

The poem suggests that true victory may lie in

- A. defeating everyone
- B. helping others and finishing together
- C. avoiding competition
- D. winning by any means

Answer: B

15. EXAM-WRITING TIP

In poetry answers, always connect event → poetic image → emotion → message. For a 4–5 mark answer, use at least two textual details and explain what they reveal rather than merely narrating the poem.